

Resume Feedback Grounding Document

Synthesized from four vetted sources: Harvard College Mignone Center for Career Success, The Muse, JMU Career Center, Indeed Career Guide. This document is the sole basis for general resume feedback, it is not to be supplemented with unattributed general internet knowledge.

Core Principles (all four sources agree, no contradictions found)

1. **Active voice, never passive.** Every bullet point should read as a direct statement of action and outcome.
2. **No first-person pronouns.** Never use "I," "me," or "my." Bullets should start directly with an action verb.
3. **Strong, meaningful action verbs.** Every bullet begins with one (e.g., "Led," "Developed," "Analyzed"), not a passive description of duties.
4. **Quantify everything possible.** Numbers, percentages, dollar amounts, and scale (team size, budget, timeframe) turn a vague claim into a credible one. "Managed a team" is weaker than "Managed a team of 12 across three departments."
5. **Consistent formatting throughout.** If one job title is bold, all job titles are bold. If one bullet ends with a period, they all do. Consistent tense: past tense for past roles, present tense for current ones.
6. **Tailor to the specific job description.** Mirror the actual keywords and phrases used in the posting, especially in the "Requirements" or "Qualifications" sections, both for human readers and automated screening systems.
7. **No personal data.** Never include race, sex, age, marital status, or a photo. This is both legally risky for employers to receive and irrelevant to qualifications.
8. **No references section.** Don't list references or write "references available upon request." This is handled separately, later in the process, only if asked.
9. **Proofread rigorously, ideally with a second set of human eyes.** Spelling and grammar errors are one of the fastest ways a resume gets discounted.
10. **Prioritize relevance over completeness.** Cut outdated or irrelevant experience (e.g., roles from 10+ years ago, unrelated minor achievements). Every line should earn its place by supporting the specific role being pursued.
11. **Highlight top achievements, not every duty.** Three to four strong, specific accomplishments per role beats an exhaustive list of responsibilities.
12. **Clean, professional formatting.** A readable font (e.g., Arial, Times New Roman) at 10-12pt, roughly one-inch margins, and enough white space that the document doesn't feel visually cramped.

On Length

Sources vary slightly in emphasis: Harvard and The Muse lean toward strict one-page brevity, especially for students and early-career candidates. Indeed frames it more flexibly, "as brief as possible without cutting key information." **Guidance: default to one page for students and early-career candidates unless there's a substantive reason (extensive relevant research, multiple advanced degrees) to go longer.**

On AI-Assisted Editing

Per Harvard's explicit guidance: AI tools are useful for *editing* (brainstorming bullet-point revisions, incorporating job-description keywords, tightening language) but should not be the primary author of resume content, AI-generated text tends to read as generic. **This directly informs how this tool's own feedback should be framed: as editing guidance and specific, actionable suggestions grounded in the user's actual content, not as a wholesale AI-written replacement resume.**

What This Tool Should NOT Do

- Should not introduce advice not traceable to the principles above
- Should not fabricate quantified metrics on the user's behalf, only point out where quantification is missing and prompt the user to supply real numbers
- Should not comment on anything related to personal data categories (even if present in a user's draft, flag its removal per Principle 7, without elaborating on why beyond "not appropriate for a resume")